



OVERTURNED: Militant attacks are up in J&K

Ceasefire Under Fire

DELHI The death of nine Indian Army personnel in an improvised explosive device (IED) blast outside Srinagar was the largest terrorist attack in recent years in Jammu and Kashmir. The unarmed soldiers were going home on leave in a bus in an army convoy bound for the state capital.

Three incidents in as many days last fortnight—a grenade attack which killed two tourists in Gulmarg, the killing of an army major and a soldier in a firefight, targeting of

Amarnath-bound devotees and the killing of five army personnel in an ambush by militants in Kupwara—mark a fresh upsurge in violence in the Valley this month.

Infiltration has also seen an upswing in the past three months with sporadic cross-border firing incidents. The violence comes even as foreign secretary-level talks between India and Pakistan are already under strain following the bombing of the Indian embassy in Kabul. The

attacks in the Valley are being attributed to militants trying to create a climate of fear ahead of the state assembly polls due later this year.

The November 2003 ceasefire ended firing on the border between India and Pakistan. This year marked the lowest levels of violence since militancy broke out in Jammu & Kashmir nearly two decades ago. Major militant groups like the Hizbul Mujahideen, which claimed responsibility for the attack on the army bus, have had their leadership and cadres decimated by security forces.

However, recent incidents have put the peace process under severe strain. "The Government and security forces have a single-point agenda to ensure that polls in J&K are held peacefully," Defence Minister A.K. Antony said. The coming weeks will indeed be testing times for the security forces in the state. **by Sandeep Unnithan**

SIGNPOSTS

WON: By the **Junior Indian men's hockey team**, the sixth Junior Asia Cup title, beating South Korea 3-2.

AWARDED: To film director **Tapan Sinha**, the Dada Saheb Phalke Award for 2006 for his outstanding



contribution to Indian cinema. His works have won him 19 national awards in

the past. He made films in Bengali, Hindi and Oriya.

DIED: Congress leader and former Uttar Pradesh minister **Khan Gufran Zahid**, 80. He was also a two-time Rajya Sabha member.

DIED: Communist leader **Chhaganrao Shingte**, 82. He had participated in the 1942 Quit India Movement.

APPOINTED: **S.C. Jamir**, as the governor of Maharashtra following the resignation of S.M. Krishna. He was the governor of Goa.

VIS-A-VIS SAIFUDDIN SOZ Union minister for water resources **versus** ASHOK KHAJURIA J&K BJP president

The Amarnath yatra should be slashed from two months to one and the annual number of pilgrims should be limited to 75,000.



SAURABH SINGH

This is an assault on Hinduism, designed to accord greater respectability to Kashmir's religious extremists and separatists.

EPILOGUE: Religion creates more strife than terror attacks which are on an upswing in the Valley.